

Advanced Passive Structures

C1 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Beyond the basic "be + past participle" passive, C1 English uses three advanced passive patterns:

- a) Passive reporting structures — used to report general beliefs, rumors or claims without naming the source.
- - It + is/was + reporting verb (said, believed, thought, reported, understood, rumored, alleged) + that-clause

e.g. It is believed that the fire started in the kitchen.

- - Subject + is/was + reporting verb + to-infinitive (simple infinitive for the same time; perfect infinitive "to have + past participle" for an earlier time)

e.g. He is believed to be abroad. / He is believed to have left the country.

- b) Passive with modals — modal + be + past participle for present/future obligation or possibility; modal + have been + past participle (modal perfect passive) for something that should/might/must have happened (or not) in the past.

e.g. The report must be submitted by Friday.

e.g. The deadline should have been extended.

- c) Get-passive — get + past participle, mainly in informal/spoken registers. It often adds a sense of something happening suddenly, unexpectedly, or with some difficulty/responsibility involved, and it can sound more dynamic than the neutral be-passive.

e.g. Our flight got cancelled at the last minute.

Compare: The flight was cancelled. (neutral, factual) vs. The flight got cancelled. (something happened to us, more personal/dramatic)

Use the reporting passive to distance yourself from a claim (useful in journalism and academic writing), the modal passive to talk about obligations/expectations, and the get-passive for informal, event-focused narration.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. He is said to have worked as a spy during the war.
- 2. It is thought that the vase dates back to the Ming dynasty.
- 3. She is rumored to be leaving the company next month.
- 4. The missing files are believed to have been destroyed.
- 5. All applications must be reviewed before Friday.

- 6. The bridge should have been repaired years ago.
- 7. My laptop got stolen on the train yesterday.
- 8. He got promoted after just one year in the role.
- 9. It is widely reported that the negotiations collapsed.
- 10. The contract is understood to have been signed under pressure.
- 11. Mistakes like this shouldn't be tolerated in a hospital.
- 12. Their car got towed while they were at the concert.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: He is said writing the letter himself.

Correct: He is said to have written the letter himself.

Why: The reporting passive needs a to-infinitive; a completed past action needs the perfect infinitive "to have + past participle."

- 2. Incorrect: The task should finished by now.

Correct: The task should have been finished by now.

Why: The modal perfect passive requires "have been," not just "been" or the bare verb.

- 3. Incorrect: The window got broke during the storm.

Correct: The window got broken during the storm.

Why: Get-passive still needs the past participle (broken), not the past simple form (broke).

- 4. Incorrect: It is said he was rich, that he owned three houses.

Correct: It is said that he was rich and owned three houses.

Why: Don't mix the that-clause pattern with a stray comma splice; join ideas with "and" or restructure into one clean that-clause.

- 5. Incorrect: The report is said to written by an intern.

Correct: The report is said to have been written by an intern.

Why: Missing "have been" — needed for a passive action that happened before now.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (choose the correct passive form)
- 1. The suspect ___ (believe / hide) somewhere near the border.
- 2. All safety checks ___ (must / complete) before takeoff.
- 3. Her necklace ___ (get / steal) at the airport last week.
- 4. The ancient manuscript ___ (think / write) in the 9th century.
- 5. The bridge ___ (should / repair) months ago, but nothing was done.

- 6. It ____ (report / that) the CEO resigned suddenly.
- 7. He ____ (rumor / offer) a position at a rival firm.
- 8. Our tickets ____ (get / upgrade) at the last minute.
- 9. The results ____ (must / announce) by noon tomorrow.
- 10. The painting ____ (allege / steal) from the museum in 1990.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite using the passive reporting structure)
- 1. People say that the company is losing money. → The company ____
- 2. They believe he escaped through the back door. → He ____
- 3. Everyone thinks the singer wrote the song herself. → The singer ____
- 4. People understood that the deal had fallen through. → It ____
- 5. Journalists reported that the minister had lied. → The minister ____
- 6. They say the castle is haunted. → The castle ____
- 7. People assume the twins are identical. → The twins ____
- C. Error Correction (find and correct one error in each sentence)
- 1. The building is thought to demolished next year.
- 2. He is said having escaped through the roof.
- 3. The proposal should approved before the deadline.
- 4. My phone got steal on the bus this morning.
- 5. It is believe that the treaty will be signed soon.
- 6. The files must has been deleted by mistake.
- D. Guided Production (write your own sentences)
- 1. Write one sentence using "is said to have + past participle" about a historical figure.
- 2. Write one sentence using a modal perfect passive (e.g., "should have been") about a mistake at work.
- 3. Write one sentence using the get-passive about something unexpected that happened to you.
- 4. Write one sentence using "It is widely believed that..." about a current news topic.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. is believed to be hiding
- 2. must be completed
- 3. got stolen
- 4. is thought to have been written
- 5. should have been repaired
- 6. is reported that
- 7. is rumored to have been offered
- 8. got upgraded
- 9. must be announced
- 10. is alleged to have been stolen
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. The company is said to be losing money.
- 2. He is believed to have escaped through the back door.
- 3. The singer is thought to have written the song herself.
- 4. It was understood that the deal had fallen through.
- 5. The minister is reported to have lied.
- 6. The castle is said to be haunted.
- 7. The twins are assumed to be identical.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. The building is thought to be demolished next year. → ...to be

demolished... (needs "be" for the passive infinitive)

- 2. He is said to have escaped through the roof. (needs "to have," not "having")
- 3. The proposal should be approved before the deadline. (needs "be approved")
- 4. My phone got stolen on the bus this morning. (past participle "stolen," not "steal")
- 5. It is believed that the treaty will be signed soon. (needs "believed," not "believe")
- 6. The files must have been deleted by mistake. (needs "have been," not "has been," after a modal)
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. Julius Caesar is said to have been stabbed by his closest allies.
- 2. The contract should have been checked more carefully before we signed it.
- 3. I got caught in a huge storm on my way home and arrived completely soaked.
- 4. It is widely believed that remote work is here to stay.

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